Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Hosea

Hosea 1:1

- This is the word of the LORD: The book of Hosea starts by stating that these are not just human words but a message from the one true God (compare Joel 1:1; Micah 1:1; Zephaniah 1:1).
- Hosea son of Beeri: Several other important people in the Old Testament are also named Hosea (or Hoshea; both names are spelled the same in Hebrew; Numbers 13:8; 2 Kings 17:1). Hosea means "the Lord saves," which is a fitting name for this prophet.
- Jeroboam ... king of Israel: Hosea gave prophecies to the northern kingdom of Israel during the reigns of its last seven kings. However, only one of them, Jeroboam II, is mentioned here (see Hosea Book Introduction, "Setting").

Hosea 1:2–3

a prostitute: Some find it hard to believe that God would tell a prophet to marry a prostitute. Because of this, many interpret this story symbolically. Early church members often thought the marriage did not actually happen. They saw it as an allegory, with Hosea representing the Lord and Gomer representing Israel.

Today, most believe the marriage was real, but they have different views on Gomer's job before marriage. Some think Gomer was a regular prostitute, while others believe she was a sacred prostitute in Canaanite fertility worship. Others think Gomer was a young woman who had not yet engaged in illicit sexual activity, but God knew she was likely to commit adultery and prostitution.

Hosea 1:2–3.5

This section describes a small part of the prophet's life, focusing on his troubled marriage. It highlights God's difficult relationship with Israel, his chosen people.

Hosea 1:4

- Jezreel is a fertile valley in north-central Israel.
- The murders Jehu committed at Jezreel are described in 2 Kings 9–10.

Hosea 1:5

King Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria fulfilled this prophecy in 733 BC by defeating the Israelite forces and capturing the Valley of Jezreel.

Hosea 1:6

Lo-ruhamah: The names of Hosea's children were part of his prophetic message (compare Isaiah 7:10–8:8).

Hosea 1:7

For many years, the kingdom of Israel relied on its armies, horses, and charioteers for security. However, this confidence was misplaced. True safety and security come from God's power as the Lord.

Hosea 1:9

- The name Lo-ammi delivers the harshest judgment because it suggests the end of Israel's covenant with the Lord. The title "my people," given to Israel when they obeyed the Lord their God (Leviticus 26:12; see also Exodus 6:7), was now taken away due to their clear unfaithfulness.
- I am not your God: The Hebrew phrase can be translated as I am not 'I Am' for you (compare Exodus 3:14). The third child's name prophetically states that the Israelites are outside the covenant and can no longer call upon the I Am.

Hosea 1:10

- the sand of the sea: This promise of future population growth for God's people repeats the promise given to the patriarchs Abraham and Jacob (Genesis 22:17; 32:12).
- they will be called 'sons of the living God.': This phrase is unique in the Old Testament, but Paul quoted it (Romans 9:26) to show that God had also called the gentiles (non-Jewsish people) to salvation.

Hosea 1:10–11

These verses show a sudden change in Hosea's prophecy from judgment to hope. In the next three verses, Hosea changes the names of Gomer's three children from symbols of divine punishment on Israel to symbols of blessing and hope. This clearly shows God's power to reverse situations from darkness to light, judgment to hope, and even death to life.

Hosea 1:11

- Judah and of Israel will be gathered together: For nearly 200 years, Israel and Judah were separate kingdoms due to political rivalry. When God restores his people, he will reunite these kingdoms under one leader, like in David's time. He will also end the curse of exile (see also Ezekiel 37:15–28).

- the day of Jezreel: Hosea said that in the future, God would restore Jezreel's original meaning. It will represent blessing and growth instead of judgment.

Hosea 2:1

- My people: God will restore the third child's name to its original meaning.
- My loved one: Israel will again receive God's love and compassion.

Hosea 2:2–23

Rebuke your mother, rebuke her: At first glance, the Lord, like an upset husband, seems to be giving a divorce to his unfaithful wife, Israel (see Deuteronomy 24:1). However, as the passage continues, it becomes clear that God's goal in this lawsuit is not divorce, but reconciliation (Hosea 2:14–23).

God's case against Israel aims to make Israel aware of her sin and offer her a chance to return to her true husband. The Lord's desire for reconciliation with Israel is surprising because the law required the death penalty for an unfaithful spouse (Deuteronomy 22:22; see also Genesis 38:24; Leviticus 21:9).

Hosea 2:3

The Lord warns unfaithful Israel that unless she repents and returns to her covenant partner, he will expose her nakedness (see also Hosea 2:10). Ezekiel also uses this image of judgment and shame (Ezekiel 16:36–37).

Hosea 2:5

The only evidence needed to prove Israel's unfaithfulness comes from her own words: I will go after my lovers. Israel's lovers were the Canaanite fertility deities, especially the baals (local representations of the god Baal). The Israelites worshiped them because they believed these gods controlled nature's reproductive forces. The Israelites attributed to them the basic necessities of life: food, water, clothing of wool and linen, and oil used for both sacred and everyday purposes.

Hosea 2:6–7

Therefore: The initial Hebrew word of Hosea 2:6 (also of 2:9 and 2:14) introduces God's judgment on Israel. Because of her idolatry, the Lord would limit Israel's access to the Canaanite fertility gods. Like an aggressive prostitute, she will chase her lovers, but she will not find them. In the end, Israel will realize it is better to return to her rightful husband.

Hosea 2:8

she does not acknowledge (literally she does not know): Israel needs to know God personally and through experience. If the Israelites had known the Lord this way, they would have understood that every good thing in their lives came from him, not from the baals (false gods).

Hosea 2:9–13

God's first judgment (Hosea 2:6–7) was to limit the Israelites. This second judgment would take away and destroy what he had given them.

Hosea 2:11

From the context (Hosea 2:13, 16–17), and similar passages in Isaiah 1:12–17 and Amos 5:21–24, it is clear that the Israelites had corrupted their festivals, new moon celebrations, and Sabbath days. They mixed worship of the Lord with worship of the Canaanite fertility god, Baal. God rejects this syncretism (mixing of different faiths) and declared he would remove these unholy days from Israel's calendar.

Hosea 2:13

While the Israelites worshiped Canaanite gods, they forgot the Lord. For Hosea, to forget means not knowing the Lord (see Hosea 8:14; 13:6; Job 8:12–13). If Israel had truly known the Lord, they would not have worshiped Baal.

Hosea 2:14–15

- The third judgment (see note on Hosea 2:6–7) is a surprise. The Lord, who had innocently suffered from Israel's repeated unfaithfulness, announces he will try to win Israel back. He will lead her into the desert, where he first made a covenant with her, away from the tempting Canaanite religion.
- The Valley of Achor was where Israel first disobeyed after entering the promised land (Joshua 7:24–26). The Lord had the will and power to give Israel a new start after their sin and trouble (Joshua 8:1–22), so Israel would again have a gateway of hope.

Hosea 2:16

- that day: This phrase is important in the prophets. It refers to the coming day of the Lord (see Joel 1:15; 2:1; Amos 5:18), when the Lord will act decisively in human history for his people.
- you will call Me 'my Husband,' and no longer call Me 'my Master: On this day, Israel will have a new relationship with God. Israel will no longer call God "master" (Hebrew ba'al), which suggests

subservience and was also the name of the main Canaanite fertility god. Instead, she will call the Lord "husband," implying partnership and companionship (Genesis 2:23–24).

Hosea 2:17

To prevent confusion between the Lord and Baal, God would remove Baal's names from the speech of the Israelites.

Hosea 2:18

On that day, the Lord will make a covenant (special agreement) with his creation and people. It will be an agreement of peace and safety.

Hosea 2:19–20

I will betroth you: This Hebrew verb, used three times in these verses, can be translated with the word betroth. In ancient times, betrothal included all the legal steps of marriage, like the groom paying a bride price. The only things missing were the marriage ceremony and sexual consummation. The Lord promised to betroth Israel to himself forever.

To ensure this eternal marriage, God provided a bride price with five priceless qualities:

1. Righteousness
2. Justice
3. Unfailing love
4. Compassion
5. Faithfulness

As a result, the Lord said, Israel will finally know me (compare Hosea 2:13).

Hosea 2:21–22

Unfaithful Israel believed her food and clothing came from her lovers, the Baals (Hosea 2:5). However, they will learn that the Lord alone provides all fertility and blessings. He will respond to the sky, the clouds, and the earth, starting the true cycle of fertility for the land. When people recognize the Lord as the only source of life, the name Jezreel will regain its true meaning: God plants!

Hosea 2:23

As God promised (Hosea 2:1), on the coming day of the Lord, he will change the names of Gomer's children. He will show compassion to No Compassion. To Not My People, he will say, You are My people. God's people should respond, You are my God.

Hosea 3:1

- Go show love to your wife again, though she: The Lord commanded Hosea to love his wife again, even though she had strayed. This act served as a testimony that the Lord promised to restore wayward Israel.
- to offer raisin cakes to idols: The worship of Asherah, a Canaanite fertility goddess, often included offerings of raisin cakes.

Hosea 3:2

So I bought her: The Bible does not explain why the prophet had to buy his wife. Many believe that the unfaithful Gomer fell into debt and became a slave. The low price Hosea paid suggests that Gomer was seen as a low-value slave (see Exodus 21:32; Leviticus 27:4).

Hosea 3:3–4

Just as Hosea's wife had to live many days without sexual relations, Israel would be without its key institutions, practices, and objects. These included the king or prince, sacrifices, and sacred pillars or idols, which were central to its life and worship.

Hosea 3:5

The Lord deprived the Israelites of these things to make them return to him with respect and see him as the only source of goodness.

Hosea 4:1

the LORD has a case against the people of the land: Hosea delivered a divine accusation against Israel for breaking their agreement with the Lord (see also Isaiah 3:13; Micah 6:2).

The accusations first highlight sins of omission, the qualities that should define the people of Israel but were missing. In Israel, there is no faithfulness, no kindness, and no knowledge of God. These important words describe the inner trust and devotion from which godly lives should arise.

Hosea 4:1–14.9

This collection of Hosea's prophecies is mostly in the order in which he made them. The prophecies began early in his ministry when Jeroboam II's was king. They ended just before Israel's destruction in 722 BC.

Hosea shares God's accusations against Israel, warns them of severe consequences for their sins, and ends with a promise of future restoration.

Hosea 4:2

The prophet also accused the Israelites of committing sins. These crimes are all forbidden in the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:3–17; Deuteronomy 5:7–21), which are the basic covenant responsibilities. Since the Israelites did not know the Lord, they failed to follow even the simplest covenant standards.

Hosea 4:3

God's judgment will always come to sinful people. Because the Israelites sinned, their land and nature would suffer.

Hosea 4:4–5

- When accused of a crime, people often blame others. However, God made it clear that Israel's apostasy was the fault of its religious leaders, priests, and false prophets.
- God's judgment on the priests and prophets was that they would stumble and fall, both in their work and in their personal lives. (The same Hebrew word is used for both kinds of stumbling.)

Hosea 4:6

- Since the priests refused to know the Lord, the people also did not know their God. As a result, the people were being destroyed.
- A main role of the priests of Israel was to know, practice, and teach the laws of God. Ironically, these guardians of the law had forgotten it.

Hosea 4:9

The people copied the bad behavior of their religious leaders. As a result, God would punish both the priests and the people for their wrong actions.

Hosea 4:10

God's judgment fits the punishment to the crime. The Israelites worshiped Canaanite fertility gods, hoping for abundant crops and herds. However, God's judgment was that they would remain hungry, and their religious practices would bring them no benefits.

Hosea 4:12

My people consult their wooden idols: For thousands of years, people have worshiped natural objects like wood and stones, thinking they held spirits and gods (Jeremiah 2:27). Biblical religion completely rejects these practices and beliefs (Exodus 20:4–5; Isaiah 44:19).

Hosea 4:13

- Many Canaanite religious rituals took place on mountaintops and hills. On these pagan "high places," sacred trees were often used in fertility worship (1 Kings 14:23; Jeremiah 2:20).
- Israelite daughters and brides also engaged in sexual acts during the worship of Baal; their fathers and husbands possibly forced them to participate.

Hosea 4:14

- God stated that he would not target young women for their prostitution. This statement contrasts with the double standards common in ancient cultures.
- prostitutes: The Hebrew word refers to female prostitutes dedicated to serving Baal and Asherah in Baal's temples (Deuteronomy 23:18).

Hosea 4:15

Beth-aven refers to the wicked acts happening at Bethel, the main worship center in northern Israel (see Amos 7:13; compare Hosea 5:8; 10:5).

Hosea 5:1

- Hosea criticizes Israel's religious and political leaders. They have led the people into idol worship, like hunters trapping animals.
- The specific sins at Mizpah and Tabor are unknown.

Hosea 5:2

I will chastise them all: This refers to God's judgment. The Hebrew word musar means "discipline." God's judgment would certainly fall on Israel's leaders. God did not judge Israel only to punish them, but to correct them so that his people would return to him.

Hosea 5:3

Israel is defiled: The word translated as defiled often appears in the first five books of the Bible to describe ritual uncleanness. This physical condition prevented a person from worshiping God in the temple (Leviticus 11–15). The prophets used this idea as a metaphor for Israel's moral uncleanness due to her idolatry (Isaiah 6:5; Micah 2:10).

Hosea 5:4

- Israel's worship of idols was so deeply rooted that the people seemed unable to return to the Lord.
- the spirit of prostitution is within them: Israel's sin was not only an action. It had become part of the nation's basic character. The people naturally chose what was corrupt instead of what was pure. Only

through God's saving work could Israel be freed from this.

Hosea 5:6–7

People might believe they can earn God's favor with sacrifices. However, Hosea warned them that they would not find him. God had left them to face the consequences of their sins.

Hosea 5:8–9

- Hosea warned the Israelites about God's coming judgment. Due to their sins, the Lord had become Israel's enemy and would punish them.
- Gibeah, Ramah, and Beth-aven (another name for Bethel) are cities in the tribal territory of Benjamin.

Hosea 5:10

those who move boundary stones: The Lord owned the land and entrusted it to the tribes after the conquest (see Joshua 13:8–19:51). Moving a boundary marker and changing God's allotted boundaries was stealing from God (Deuteronomy 19:14). Such an act rightly brought divine punishment (Deuteronomy 27:17).

Hosea 5:12

a moth ... decay: Sin can slowly weaken a people at their core, and they may not realize the damage until it is already done.

Hosea 5:13

To prevent complete destruction, the Israelites removed King Pekah and made Hoshea the new king. Hoshea asked the Assyrian king Shalmaneser for peace (2 Kings 15:29–30; 17:3), but these efforts could not save Israel. Assyria would soon destroy them.

Hosea 5:15

Hosea reminded Israel that divine judgment was not just punishment. God's goal was to persuade Israel to admit their guilt and return to the Lord (see Hosea 2:2, 14).

Hosea 6:1–3

- After God judged Israel, the religious leaders asked the people to repent and know the Lord.
- The rains that came in early spring were essential for growing crops.

Hosea 6:4

Israel's response was not enough. God lamented that their love vanished like morning mist and dew.

Hosea 6:6

In one of Hosea's key verses, God highlights the most important qualities for the Israelites' covenant lives with him:

1. The Lord wants his people to show love more than he wants sacrifices. Love (the Hebrew word khesed, meaning loyal love shown through steady faithfulness) includes being faithful in relationships (see Hosea 4:1; 6:4). God is always faithful (Psalm 136), and he expects the same from his people.
2. The Lord wants Israel to know him more than he wants burnt offerings. Knowing God means more than just knowing facts about him (see "Knowing God" Theme Note). A close personal relationship with God involves complete trust and integrity.

Sacrifice still had a proper place in Israelite religion, but only when offered by people who truly knew and loved God (see Isaiah 1:10–17; Amos 5:21–24; Micah 6:6–8).

Hosea 6:7–11

Hosea describes how human rebellion against God started with Adam and spread through Israel's cities to Judah.

Hosea 6:9

Like raiders who lie in ambush, so does a band of priests: Hosea again condemns the religious leaders for their crimes (see Hosea 4:4–8).

Hosea 6:10

a horrible thing: The prophet uses this rare word (also in Jeremiah 18:13) to describe how deeply Israel sinned by breaking God's covenant and betraying his trust.

Hosea 7:1–2

- When I heal Israel: God deeply desired to heal Israel's unfaithfulness (see Hosea 14:4) and restore her relationship with him. However, Israel was full of liars, thieves, and bandits.
- The Israelites might have believed that the Lord was unaware of their sins, but he was watching them and saw everything they did.

Hosea 7:3

The prophet did not record the king's name. Many people believe it was Hoshea, the last king of the northern kingdom.

Hosea 7:3–7

The northern kingdom of Israel had seven different kings during the last twenty-five years of its history. Four of these kings were killed by men who seized the throne. This passage refers to the violent and bloody political struggles that happened in those years.

Hosea 7:4

adulterers: Hosea used this term earlier to describe spiritual betrayal (Hosea 3:1). Here, it refers to those who were unfaithful to the king.

Hosea 7:6

A simile effectively compares the plots and political intrigue of this turbulent time to a red-hot oven that sets the entire land on fire.

Hosea 7:7

All their kings fall: The people of Israel killed their kings one after another. They did this to try to save their nation and their lives from the Assyrian army. During these final years, they relied on their own plans and schemes. They never thought to ask the Lord for help, who was their only true source of help.

Hosea 7:8

- Ephraim mixes with the nations: By trusting foreign nations instead of God for safety, the Israelites lost their purity and holiness, which set them apart for the Lord.
- Flatbread needs turning at the right time to bake evenly on both sides. Otherwise, it burns on one side and stays raw on the other. Israel was like a half-baked cake and thus became worthless.

Hosea 7:8–12

Israel ignored the Lord in both their international and domestic decisions. Like confused and helpless doves, they moved back and forth between Assyria and Egypt, trying in vain to make treaties that would save their land. Assyria and Egypt were the major powers of their time.

Hosea 7:9

Foreigners: Israel's political relationships with other nations had damaged their spiritual health.

Hosea 7:11

When Assyria invaded, Israel asked Egypt for help. When Egypt could not help, Israel tried to please Assyria by becoming its vassal (a kingdom that serves a stronger power).

Hosea 7:12

Like a hunter catching birds, the Lord would trap foolish Israel to punish them.

Hosea 7:13

- Woe: The Hebrew word 'oy was used at funerals to mourn the dead. In God's eyes, Israel was as good as dead because they had rebelled against him. Rebelling against a human king was a capital crime. It was even more serious for God's people to rebel against their heavenly king.
- I would redeem them: This Hebrew word means paying a fee to bring back someone who has been enslaved. It is often linked to the exodus from Egypt. The Lord wanted to do for the Israelites what he did when he freed their ancestors from slavery to pagan gods, but they lied about him.

Hosea 7:14

They slash themselves: Hurting their own bodies was a common part of Canaanite worship (see 1 Kings 18:28). This practice was forbidden in Israel (Deuteronomy 14:1).

Hosea 7:16

A faulty or loose bow cannot shoot an arrow to the target. This represents Israel's failure without God (see Hosea 7:8, 11).

Hosea 8:1

- Put the ram's horn to your lips!: The ram's horn trumpet (shofar) called people to worship (Psalm 98:6); it also signaled battle (2 Samuel 20:1). God was sending an enemy, the Assyrians, to carry out his judgment on Israel.
- rebelled against My law: God's law (Hebrew torah) is more than just the individual laws in the Pentateuch. It represents all of God's teachings to his people through his words and actions.

Loving fulfillment of the Torah was Israel's part of the covenant. They had broken God's commandments and turned away from their covenant relationship with the Lord.

Hosea 8:3

Jesus says that only God is good (Mark 10:18). God is the source of all good things, but Israel rejected him.

Hosea 8:4

They make princes, but without My approval: They quickly removed one king and chose another if they believed it would save their nation (see Hosea 7:7). They did all of this without consulting their true king, the Lord.

Hosea 8:5–6

your calf: Jeroboam I was the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel. He ruled from 931 to 910 BC. When he became king, he set up worship places in Dan and Bethel. He did this to prevent people from traveling to the temple in Jerusalem, the capital of the southern kingdom. At each site, he placed a gold calf for the people to worship (1 Kings 12:26–30).

Hosea 8:7

When Hosea announced God's judgment, the punishment fit the crime (see study note on Hosea 4:10). Through their idol worship and political schemes, the Israelites caused their own downfall (see Galatians 6:7).

Hosea 8:9

like a wild donkey: Hosea compared Israel's worship of the Canaanite fertility gods to an animal eager to mate (see Jeremiah 2:23–24).

Hosea 8:10

I will now round them up: God sometimes promises to gather his people to save them (Zechariah 10:8–10), but here the Lord gathers them for judgment (Joel 3:11).

Hosea 8:11

Ephraim multiplied the altars for sin: As Israel increased its worship of other gods, the people also increased their religious activities in an attempt to remove their sin. Instead, these practices only added to their sin.

Hosea 8:13

- they offer sacrifices ... the LORD does not accept them: See Hosea 6:6; Isaiah 1:10–17; Amos 5:21–24; Micah 6:6–8.
- They will return to Egypt, the place of slavery (Deuteronomy 28:68). God's actions with Israel did not end with judgment. The purpose of judgment was to restore Israel to their status when they left Egypt, allowing them to start anew (see Hosea 2:14–15).

Hosea 8:14

- Israel has forgotten his Maker: See Hosea 2:13.
- God's judgment often appears as fire sent upon the royal palaces and fortresses (see Amos 1:4, 7).

Hosea 9:1

- Do not rejoice: This likely refers to the Feast of Tabernacles, when Israel celebrated the year's final harvest. God ordained this festival (Deuteronomy 16:13–15), but the Israelites turned it into a wild pagan celebration, acting like other nations.
- you have played the harlot (literally you have loved a prostitute's pay): The Israelites mistakenly believed their grain and wine were rewards for worshiping the Canaanite fertility god.

Hosea 9:2

As punishment for their actions, the Lord would reduce the Israelites' harvests. This would cause them to go hungry (compare Haggai 1:3–11).

Hosea 9:3

God would send the Israelites into exile in Assyria in 722 BC. There, in a land considered unclean, they would eat food that was ceremonially unclean. This would separate them even more from their covenant with the Lord.

Hosea 9:4

In exile, the Israelites could not offer proper sacrifices because any sacrifice in a foreign land was considered unclean and defiled.

Hosea 9:6

Even if some Israelites escaped the Assyrian exile by fleeing to Egypt, God's judgment would still reach them there.

Hosea 9:7

The Israelites who turned away from their faith did not believe God's warnings from the prophets. They mocked the prophets, calling them crazy.

Hosea 9:8

The watchman stood on the city wall to warn of any threat (for example, 1 Samuel 14:16). Similarly, a prophet was God's watchman. They warned Israel about her sins and the judgment that would follow (see Jeremiah 6:17; Ezekiel 3:17). Even though the prophet served the people, they responded to him with hostility.

Hosea 9:9

as in the days of Gibeah: See Judges 19–21.

Hosea 9:10

I found Israel: Hosea, like Ezekiel (Ezekiel 16), describes the Lord finding and adopting pure, innocent Israel in the desert. But Israel soon left God for idols at Baal-peor (Numbers 25:1–4). Worshiping idols made the Israelites detestable. This strong word can also mean abomination (Deuteronomy 29:17; Jeremiah 7:30). They inevitably became like what they worshiped.

Hosea 9:11

Israel worshiped the baals in hopes of having many children. But God would punish them by preventing conception, pregnancy, and birth.

Hosea 9:13

for slaughter: Instead of having more children, the Israelites' worship of idols would lead to their children's deaths.

Hosea 9:15

- All their evil appears at Gilgal: Gilgal was the base camp for Joshua's army (Joshua 5:10; 10:6, 43) and the place where Saul became king (1 Samuel 11:15). Saul also disobeyed God and was rejected as king at Gilgal (1 Samuel 13:8–15; 15:10–23). Israel's leaders, including its first king, led the nation away from their true king, the Lord.
- I will no longer love them: Although a different Hebrew word is used here, the prophetic judgment reflects the name of Hosea's daughter (Hosea 1:6).

Hosea 9:17

wanderers: God would judge the Israelites by removing them from the land, leaving them without a home.

Hosea 10:1

- Although Israel was God's rich and fruitful vine (see Isaiah 5:1–7; Jeremiah 2:21; Ezekiel 17:6), she wrongly credited her success to the Canaanite fertility gods instead of the Lord. She used the wealth God gave her to enhance idol worship.
- sacred pillars: Stone pillars could serve as acceptable memorials (Genesis 35:20; Joshua 24:26–27), but God forbade the Israelites from using them in worship like the Canaanites did (Exodus 23:24; Deuteronomy 16:22).

Hosea 10:3

We have no king: Some interpreters understand these words as an admission, after Israel's destruction, that they had been punished and that their line of kings had come to an end because they did not fear the Lord. Others see this statement as the Israelites' arrogant rejection of the Lord's kingship.

Hosea 10:4

The corruption of justice is like bitter, poisonous weeds (Amos 6:12).

Hosea 10:5–6

The Assyrians would take Israel's gold calf idol (see Hosea 8:5–6) as a war prize.

Hosea 10:8

The Israelites who survived the disaster would only be able to cry out to the mountains and hills, Cover us! ... Fall on us!

Hosea 10:9–10

The terrible events at Gibeah (Judges 19–21) set a pattern of sin for the people of the northern kingdom of Israel (see Hosea 9:9). God punished them by allowing a major defeat in war, similar to the time of the judges (see Judges 2:10–15).

Hosea 10:11

Because Israel did not keep the covenant, the Lord gave her a heavy burden. This was divine correction to bring her back to him.

Hosea 10:12

Using farming metaphors, God explained his requirements for his people and promised blessings if they obeyed (see Hosea 6:6; 8:7). Although Hosea announced God's judgment, he also gave Israel the chance to repent and receive blessings.

Hosea 10:14

as Shalman devastated Beth-arbel: This event is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible or in other sources, but Hosea's audience clearly knew about it.

Hosea 11:1

My son: The Lord adopted Israel when he delivered them from Egypt. This verse refers to Jesus in Matthew 2:15 (see study note on Matthew 4:1–11).

Hosea 11:1–11

God grieved over Israel's unfaithfulness. Even after all he had done for them, Israel had turned into a rebellious people. Justice required serious punishment, but the final decision about Israel's future would come from God's tender compassion for his people, not from an abstract rule.

Hosea 11:2

Despite God's love, Israel acted like a rebellious child, offering sacrifices to Baal. The punishment for a rebellious son was death (Deuteronomy 21:18–21).

Hosea 11:3–4

God cared for the young nation of Israel with kindness and love.

Hosea 11:5–7

Since the Israelites refused to return to the Lord, they would go back to Egypt and serve Assyria. Their past slavery in Egypt symbolized their future exile in Assyria.

Hosea 11:8

- Although justice required Israel's death, the Lord hesitated to give up Israel, let them go, or destroy his son.
- Admah and Zeboiim were cities near Sodom and Gomorrah that God completely destroyed (Deuteronomy 29:23).
- In Hebrew thought, the heart is the center of intellect and will.

Hosea 11:9

- I will not: The Lord alone would decide Israel's fate. God repeated I will not three times to stress his choice not to destroy his people completely.
- The reason for this divine decision is, I am ... the Holy One among you. God's holiness sets him apart from all creation (see "God's Absolute Holiness" Theme Note). An offended person might destroy a rebel out of anger and spite. The Holy One does not act from those motives.

Hosea 11:10–11

Israel's sin would not be the final word. God, in his holy love, would roar like a lion (see Amos 1:2; 3:8) to call his people home from exile in Babylon.

Hosea 11:12–12.14

Israel has engaged in deception and dishonesty since Jacob's time.

Hosea 12:1

- a covenant with Assyria: To save his land, Hoshea became a vassal of King Shalmaneser of Assyria (2 Kings 17:3). Hoshea soon rebelled against Shalmaneser by withholding tribute and sought support from King So of Egypt (2 Kings 17:4).
- east wind: See study note on Job 38:24–27.

Hosea 12:3

- he grasped his brother's heel (literally he supplanted his brother): The Hebrew verb 'aqab is the root of Jacob's name. Even before birth, Jacob lived up to his name by supplanting his brother Esau (Genesis 25:26).
- As an adult, Jacob even fought with God (see Genesis 32:22–30) and was renamed "Israel," meaning "God fights."

Hosea 12:4

he found Him at Bethel: See Genesis 28:11–22.

Hosea 12:6

The Lord urged Israel to stop living like Jacob. Instead, they should return to God and act with love and justice.

Hosea 12:7–8

- During the reign of Jeroboam II (793–753 BC), Israelite merchants became very wealthy. They often used deceitful business practices like dishonest scales (see Amos 8:5–6).
- The Hebrew term for merchants is kena'an ("Canaan"). Canaanite traders were known in the ancient world for their crafty dealings. The Israelites imitated their pagan neighbors in both religion and commerce.

Hosea 12:9

I will again make you dwell in tents: This judgment on the wealthy Israelite merchants means they will return to the simple homes of the exodus. There is also hope here. God's plan to save Israel will start again in the wilderness (see Hosea 2:14–15).

Hosea 12:11

Gilead and Gilgal were cities where Israelites worshiped Baal instead of the Lord (see Hosea 4:15; 6:8; 9:15).

Hosea 12:13

by a prophet: Moses obeyed God faithfully, which contrasts with Israel's disobedience.

Hosea 13:1

- At the height of its power, the tribe of Ephraim caused fear among other Israelites (see Isaiah 7:2).
- he [Ephraim] died: Because of their idolatry, they separated themselves from the Lord, the only true source of life.

Hosea 13:2

- The Hebrew word for idols is the same as the one used for the golden calf (Exodus 32:4, 8; see also Hosea 10:5–6; Amos 5:5–6).
- Kiss the calves!: Canaanite religious ceremonies involved kissing images of Baal (1 Kings 19:18).

Hosea 13:3

- God judged idolatrous Ephraim by saying they would disappear (compare Hosea 6:4).
- Mist, dew, chaff, and smoke all represent things that do not last.

Hosea 13:4–5

there is no Savior: The Lord proved this to Israel during the exodus and their time in the wilderness.

Hosea 13:6

their hearts became proud, and. ... forgot Me: They did not rely on the Lord for safety. Instead, they trusted their kings, armies, and wealth (see Hosea 2:13).

Hosea 13:7–8

God judged Israel using the Assyrian army as his tool for punishment. The description of God's attack highlights the Assyrians' cruelty to those they conquered.

Hosea 13:9

Me ... your helper: See Psalms 70:5; 115:9; 121:2; 124:8. Israel's sin had turned their helper into their destroyer.

Hosea 13:10

Where is your king: When Hoshea's alliance with Egypt failed (see Hosea 12:1), he attempted to make peace with Assyria. However, they captured and imprisoned him (2 Kings 17:4). The Israelites had depended on their armies and kings for salvation instead of the Lord, and now no one could save them.

Hosea 13:11

Israel had chosen its kings without asking the Lord, so now he would take them away in anger.

Hosea 13:12

God had carefully stored up the record of Israel's sin and guilt. He could not escape his punishment.

Hosea 13:13

Israel was like a child in the womb who resisted being born (an unwise son). Amazingly, Israel preferred to stay in the womb rather than receive life from the Lord.

Hosea 13:14

Sheol refers to the realm of the dead (see Job 3:11–19; see also study note on Job 7:9). The Lord rules over Sheol and could save Israel if he chose to. However, he will not show mercy to the Israelites and calls upon death to punish them.

Hosea 13:16

- In 722 BC, Assyria captured Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:5–6). Thousands died during the three-year siege, and many more were exiled. This happened because they rebelled against their God.
- The terrible act of killing pregnant women is also mentioned in Amos 1:13 and 2 Kings 15:16.

Hosea 14:1–9

Destruction was not God's final message to his covenant people. Although judgment must happen, God's healing and restoring grace is stronger than human sin.

Hosea 14:2–3

- Hosea created a prayer of confession to guide his people back to the Lord. God's prophets felt both God's anger over Israel's rebellion and the people's suffering (see also Daniel 9:4–19).
- Take away all our iniquity: The Israelites should rely on God's mercy and grace, openly admitting their many sins.
- that we may present the fruit of our lips: Israel often offered animal sacrifices for sin, but the Lord made it clear that sacrifices were not the answer (see Hosea 6:6). Israel should give God true repentance.

Hosea 14:3

The Israelites must give up their reliance on idols, foreign alliances, and their military strength. Even though they were God's children (Hosea 11:1), their rebellion made them orphans. When they sincerely and fully repented, they could find mercy again.

Hosea 14:4

I will heal their apostasy: Only God can cure the disease of sin. The Lord heals all our physical and spiritual diseases (Psalm 103:3).

Hosea 14:5

- like the dew: In Israel's semi-desert climate, dew provided essential moisture for life (Genesis 27:28; Deuteronomy 33:28).
- take root: When Israel remained faithful to their covenant with the Lord, they became solid and stable like the majestic cedars in Lebanon (Psalm 92:12).

Hosea 14:5–7

Hosea describes the effect of God's healing love on repentant Israel. God promises to provide the fertility that Israel had sought from the baals.

Hosea 14:7

in his shade: A safe and comforting place (Psalm 91:1; Isaiah 25:4).

Hosea 14:8

Hosea urges Israel one last time to avoid idols. Their life comes only from the Lord, who is like an evergreen tree that always produces fruit.

Hosea 14:9

This final verse praises Hosea's words to wise and thoughtful believers of all generations.